

Stakeholder Engagement Plan

Project Title: Domain-Specific Small Language Model for African Folktales

Team Name: Ethopie

Team Members:

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1. Identify Two Stakeholder Groups

Stakeholder Group 1: Community Elders & Local Storytellers

- **Who they are:** The traditional custodians of regional histories and oral traditions.
- **Why they are important:** They serve as the primary source for authentic structural and contextual verification of the folktales.
- **What matters most to them:** The exact cultural accuracy of their storytelling traditions, the protection of sacred knowledge from public distribution, and retaining ownership over their digitized heritage.

Stakeholder Group 2: Local Educators & Cultural Guardians

- **Who they are:** Teachers, local writers, African literature scholars, and administrators of cultural centers.

- **Why they are important:** They will integrate the model's outputs into schools and digital archives to teach younger, digitally native generations.
- **What matters most to them:** Having accessible, dialect-aware reading materials that reinforce indigenous literacy without homogenizing unique tribal identities.

2. Potential Benefits and Risks

Stakeholder Group 1: Community Elders & Local Storytellers

- **Potential Benefits:** The project provides a modern avenue to revitalize oral traditions, ensuring their ancestral wisdom is passed down rather than lost over time.
- **Potential Harms/Concerns:** The synthetic generation of stories might inadvertently lower the perceived value of real-world oral historians. There is also an economic and ethical risk of data exploitation if these communities are disconnected from the ownership of the transcribed texts.
- **Considerations:** Strict adherence to indigenous data sovereignty is required, including the complete exclusion of sacred or restricted community knowledge.

Stakeholder Group 2: Local Educators & Cultural Guardians

- **Potential Benefits:** Provides schools and cultural centers with a highly interactive digital archive and accurate reading materials to aid in indigenous education.
- **Potential Harms/Concerns:** There is a major cultural risk of accidental homogenization, where diverse storytelling traditions merge into a generic output, eroding distinct regional identities.
- **Considerations:** Addressing the uncertainty of historical accuracy in early colonial text translations to ensure modern students are not taught historical colonial distortions.

3. Engagement Method

Stakeholder Group 1: Community Elders & Local Storytellers

- **Method:** Participatory Design.

- **Why it is appropriate & suitable:** It centers local agency and allows the communities to actively shape the knowledge base rather than simply having their data extracted. It is the most effective way to capture natural colloquial storytelling and authentic structural markers directly from the source.
- **How it would be conducted:** Through fieldwork recordings of oral histories, community-led audio transcripts, and accepting direct text contributions submitted by local storytellers.

Stakeholder Group 2: Local Educators & Cultural Guardians

- **Method:** User Committees (Specifically, a Community Review Board).
- **Why it is appropriate & suitable:** Establishing a formal board provides structured oversight and inter-rater reliability testing across annotators. It aligns with their role as evaluators and teachers, giving them direct control over the quality of the educational materials.
- **How it would be conducted:** Forming a Community Review Board made up of local educators, writers, and cultural guardians. This board will conduct regular evaluations of model checkpoints and hold complete veto power over distributions.

4. Influence on Project Design

- **Dataset:** Feedback from local storytellers dictates strict rejection thresholds; any source document flagged as heavily distorted by historical bias or culturally misattributed will be completely dropped from the training set. It also drives the active incorporation of localized African English, French, and Portuguese pidgins/creoles.
- **Model Design:** Engagement with cultural anthropologists and elders informs the internal classification setup. The model will use multi-label tokens for geographic origin, thematic archetypes, and narrative devices to prevent homogenization.
- **Outputs:** Feedback ensures the narrative flow inherently replicates traditional oral structures, such as call-and-response cues, rhythmic proverbs, and community-centric dialogue.
- **Evaluation:** Local educators will provide continuous human-in-the-loop evaluation to identify narrative hallucinations, repetitive text patterns, and harmful stereotypes.

- **Deployment:** Deployment decisions are entirely governed by the community. The Community Review Board holds complete veto power over model distributions and updates if any output disrespects, exploits, or misrepresents their shared cultural heritage.